



* Neither side could win, so they stopped fighting and agreed to exchange hostages instead. The Aesir sent wise Mimir and a god called Hoenir to live in Vanaheim. At first Hoenir appeared to give good advice, but the Vanir soon noticed that this only happened when Mimir was close enough to whisper into his ear. When Hoenir was on his own he always said, “Let others decide.” The Vanir realized that Hoenir was not a valuable hostage at all, but an empty-headed fool.

* *The Vanir gods were infuriated by this trickery.
They cut off Mimir’s head and sent it back to Asgard.*

* Distressed by the loss of his cleverest adviser, Odin sang spells over Mimir’s head and rubbed herbs into the skin to preserve it, so that the head continued to give advice to Odin.

Despite the Aesir’s treachery, the gods did not restart their war. Instead they all gathered together, spat into a cauldron and used this spittle to create Kvasir, the wisest of all beings, as a pledge of peace. The Aesir and the Vanir learned that despite their differences they were better off as friends.

